

How Much Land Does a Man Need?

Leo Tolstoy · 1886

First published: tr. Louise and Aylmer Maude, 1906

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: Caspar David Friedrich, The Monk by the Sea (1808–1810). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Twenty-three_Tales/How_Much_Land_Does_a_Man_Need? (revision 13888504), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 7–11 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does How Much Land Does a Man Need? suggest about greed?
- What does How Much Land Does a Man Need? suggest about contentment?
- What does How Much Land Does a Man Need? suggest about the devil's temptation?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	How Much Land Does a Man Need?	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*greed* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: How Much Land Does a Man Need?

Focus: greed that grasps more than a person needs

Content note (death from exhaustion): Sensitive content: Death from exhaustion. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes death from exhaustion.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Peasant Pahóm boasts that with enough land he would fear not even the Devil, who overhears. Pahóm buys land, then more, always wanting more. The Bashkirs offer as much land as he can walk around in a day for a thousand rubles, if he returns by sunset. He walks too far, runs back, reaches the starting point at sunset and falls dead. His servant digs a grave six feet long: all the land he needed.

Background: Written 1886. Translation: Louise and Aylmer Maude, Twenty-Three Tales (1906), public domain in the US. The Bashkirs are a Turkic people of the southern Urals.

Significance: A widely taught parable; James Joyce reportedly called it the greatest story in world literature.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: How do you know when you have enough? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes death from exhaustion.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are haggled, disparaged, burdening, freehold, glistened. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "Pahóm bargained and haggled with him, and at last they settled the price at 1,500 roubles, part in cash and part to be paid later." In this sentence it means: argued over a price. Word histories: "glistened": From Old English glisnian "to gleam," a Germanic word related to glitter and gleam. (Not from Latin tenere.) For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of How Much Land Does a Man Need? would have known. Written 1886. Translation: Louise and Aylmer Maude, Twenty-Three Tales (1906), public domain in the US. The Bashkirs are a Turkic people of the southern Urals. Why does this story matter? A widely taught parable; James Joyce reportedly called it the greatest story in world literature. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for irony.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "Close to the village there lived a lady, a small landowner, who had an estate of about three hundred acres." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to greed that grasps more than a person needs? I circle "burdening", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find irony, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for irony.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of irony. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *Close to the village there lived a lady, a small landowner, who had an estate of about three hundred acres. She had always lived on good terms with the peasants, until she engaged as her steward an old soldier, who took to burdening the people with fines. However careful Pahóm tried to be, it happened again and again that now a horse of his got among the lady's oats, now a cow strayed into her garden, now his calves found their way into her meadows—and he always had to pay a fine.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Irony, Symbolism, Theme: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how How Much Land Does a Man Need? develops the idea of greed that grasps more than a person needs. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim. Read in the public-domain translation by Louise Maude and Aylmer Maude.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to greed? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about greed that grasps more than a person needs, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how irony shapes greed that grasps more than a person needs. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
haggled (verb)	argued over a price	*Pahóm bargained and haggled with him, and at last they settled the price at 1,500 roubles, part in cash and part to be paid later.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
disparaged (verb)	spoke of something as having little worth	*The younger sister was piqued, and in turn disparaged the life of a tradesman, and stood up for that of a peasant.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
burdening (verb)	weight down with a load	*She had always lived on good terms with the peasants, until she engaged as her steward an old soldier, who took to burdening the people with fines.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
freehold (noun)	land owned outright	*The peasants had plenty of land: every man had twenty-five acres of Communal land given him for his use, and any one who had money could buy, besides, at two shillings an acre as much good freehold land as he wanted.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
glistened (verb)	be shiny, as if wet	*Pahóm's eyes glistened: it was all virgin soil, as flat as the palm of your hand, as black as the seed of a poppy, and in the hollows different kinds of grasses grew breast high.*	“glistened”: From Old English glisnian "to gleam," a Germanic word related to glitter and gleam. (Not from Latin tenere.) (Online Etymology Dictionary, https://www.etymonline.com/word/glisten)
civilly (adverb)	in a civil manner	*He appealed to them most civilly, but they still went on: now the Communal herdsmen would let the*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

		village cows stray into his meadows; then horses from the night pasture would get among his corn.	
carpets (noun)	floor covering consisting of a piece of thick heavy fabric (usually with nap or pile)	*I gave away about one hundred roubles' worth of dressing-gowns and carpets, besides a case of tea, and I gave wine to those who would drink it; and I got the land for less than twopence an acre.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
pitched (verb)	settled on; chose	*On and on they went until they had gone more than three hundred miles, and on the seventh day they came to a place where the Bashkírs had pitched their tents.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
assembled (verb)	create by putting components or members together	*The Bashkírs rose and assembled, and the Chief came, too.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
remaining (verb)	stay the same; remain in a certain state	*Then he took off his outer coat, remaining in his sleeveless under coat.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. How do you know when you have enough?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with greed?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Who overhears Pahóm's boast? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: The Devil
2. What do the Bashkirs offer? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: All the land he can walk around in a day
3. What is the price? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A thousand rubles a day

4. What must Pahóm do to keep the land? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Return to the starting point by sunset
5. How much land does Pahóm need in the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Six feet, for his grave
6. Retell the three most important events of "How Much Land Does a Man Need?" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Peasant Pahóm boasts that with enough land he would fear not even the Devil, who overhears. Pahóm buys land, then more, always wanting more. The Bashkirs offer as much land as he can walk around in a day for a thousand rubles, if he returns by sunset. He walks too far, runs back, reaches the starting point at sunset and falls dead. His servant digs a grave six feet long: all the land he needed.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "How Much Land Does a Man Need?"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "How Much Land Does a Man Need?" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "Pahóm bargained and haggled with him, and at last they settled the price at 1,500 roubles, part in cash and part to be paid later." What does "haggled" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: haggled: argued over a price.
10. Reread: "The younger sister was piqued, and in turn disparaged the life of a tradesman, and stood up for that of a peasant." What does "disparaged" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: disparaged: spoke of something as having little worth.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "How Much Land Does a Man Need?" suggest about greed that grasps more than a person needs? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A widely taught parable; James Joyce reportedly called it the greatest story in world literature.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about greed that grasps more than a person needs? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
4. In the passage that begins "Close to the village there lived a lady, a small landowner, who had an estate of about three hundred acres.", why might Tolstoy have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in "How Much Land Does a Man Need?", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Peasant Pahóm boasts that with enough land he would fear not even the Devil, who overhears. Pahóm buys land, then more, always wanting more. The Bashkirs offer as much land as he can walk around in a day for a thousand rubles, if he returns by sunset. He walks too far, runs back, reaches the…

6. As the opening story, what does "How Much Land Does a Man Need?" set up that the rest of How Much Land Does a Man Need? will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: "How do you know when you have enough?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does theme appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with greed? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for statements or moments that connect to the book's big ideas.
10. Background: Written 1886. Translation: Louise and Aylmer Maude, Twenty-Three Tales (1906), public domain in the US. The Bashkirs are a Turkic people of the southern Urals. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "A widely taught parable; James Joyce reportedly called it the greatest story in world literature." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "How Much Land Does a Man Need?" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about greed that grasps more than a person needs? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "How Much Land Does a Man Need?": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to contentment: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Tolstoy need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "How Much Land Does a Man Need?" treats greed that grasps more than a person needs with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does How Much Land Does a Man Need? see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve greed? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about greed that grasps more than a person needs? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Leo Tolstoy about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Theme**: statements or moments that connect to the book's big ideas

Chapter quiz

1. Who overhears Pahóm's boast?
   A. A Bashkir
   B. His wife
   C. The Devil
   D. A landlord
2. What do the Bashkirs offer?
   A. A free farm
   B. Gold
   C. A herd of horses
   D. All the land he can walk around in a day
3. What is the price?
   A. Ten rubles an acre
   B. His house
   C. A thousand rubles a day
   D. Nothing
4. What must Pahóm do to keep the land?
   A. Return to the starting point by sunset
   B. Plant wheat
   C. Marry a Bashkir
   D. Pay tax
5. How much land does Pahóm need in the end?
   A. Six feet, for his grave
   B. None
   C. A hundred acres
   D. The whole steppe

6. In the line “Pahóm bargained and haggled with him, and at last they settled the price at 1,500 roubles, part in cash and part to be paid later.”, what does “haggled” most nearly mean?
   A. argued over a price
   B. spoke of something as having little worth
   C. land owned outright
   D. weight down with a load
7. In the line “The younger sister was piqued, and in turn disparaged the life of a tradesman, and stood up for that of a peasant.”, what does “disparaged” most nearly mean?
   A. spoke of something as having little worth
   B. argued over a price
   C. weight down with a load
   D. land owned outright

Answer key: 1. C (The Devil); 2. D (All the land he can walk around in a day); 3. C (A thousand rubles a day); 4. A (Return to the starting point by sunset); 5. A (Six feet, for his grave); 6. A (argued over a price); 7. A (spoke of something as having little worth)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.1, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “How Much Land Does a Man Need?,” how does Tolstoy show greed that grasps more than a person needs? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In How Much Land Does a Man Need?, how does Tolstoy develop the idea of greed that grasps more than a person needs? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea. Read in the public-domain translation by Louise Maude and Aylmer Maude.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how How Much Land Does a Man Need? develops the idea of greed that grasps more than a person needs. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim. Read in the public-domain translation by Louise Maude and Aylmer Maude.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of How Much Land Does a Man Need? (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of greed that grasps more than a person needs. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what How Much Land Does a Man Need? suggests about greed that grasps more than a person needs. Lay out two plausible interpretations,

weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Leo Tolstoy uses irony in How Much Land Does a Man Need? to complicate the reader's understanding of greed that grasps more than a person needs. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate How Much Land Does a Man Need? within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of greed that grasps more than a person needs responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read How Much Land Does a Man Need? alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of greed that grasps more than a person needs follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to How Much Land Does a Man Need? and its treatment of greed that grasps more than a person needs. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads How Much Land Does a Man Need? as evidence for a larger claim about greed that grasps more than a person needs in How Much Land Does a Man Need?. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads How Much Land Does a Man Need? as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of greed that grasps more than a person needs. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on How Much Land Does a Man Need?.

SAT-style questions

1. *She had always lived on good terms with the peasants, until she engaged as her steward an old soldier, who took to burdening the people with fines.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “burdening” most nearly mean?

   A. create by putting components or members together

   B. weight down with a load

   C. settled on; chose

D. stay the same; remain in a certain state

2. *Close to the village there lived a lady, a small landowner, who had an estate of about three hundred acres. She had always lived on good terms with the peasants, until she engaged as her steward an old soldier, who took to burdening the people with fines. However careful Pahóm tried to be, it happened again and again that now a horse of his got among the lady's oats, now a cow strayed into her garden, now his calves found their way into her meadows—and he always had to pay a fine.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "How Much Land Does a Man Need?"?

A. A family and a house collapsing together

B. Greed that grasps more than a person needs

C. Courage and guilt in a small community

D. Science that poisons love

SAT key: 1. B (weight down with a load); 2. B (Greed that grasps more than a person needs)

Whole-book test

How Much Land Does a Man Need?: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Who overhears Pahóm's boast?
   A. A Bashkir
   B. His wife
   C. The Devil
   D. A landlord
2. What do the Bashkirs offer?
   A. A free farm
   B. Gold
   C. A herd of horses
   D. All the land he can walk around in a day
3. What is the price?
   A. Ten rubles an acre
   B. His house
   C. A thousand rubles a day
   D. Nothing
4. What must Pahóm do to keep the land?
   A. Return to the starting point by sunset
   B. Plant wheat
   C. Marry a Bashkir
   D. Pay tax
5. How much land does Pahóm need in the end?
   A. Six feet, for his grave
   B. None
   C. A hundred acres
   D. The whole steppe
6. In the line “Pahóm bargained and haggled with him, and at last they settled the price at 1,500 roubles, part in cash and part to be paid later.”, what does “haggled” most nearly mean?
   A. argued over a price
   B. spoke of something as having little worth
   C. land owned outright
   D. weight down with a load

7. In the line “The younger sister was piqued, and in turn disparaged the life of a tradesman, and stood up for that of a peasant.”, what does “disparaged” most nearly mean?
   A. spoke of something as having little worth
   B. argued over a price
   C. weight down with a load
   D. land owned outright
8. As used in the story (“Pahóm bargained and haggled with him, and at last they settled the price at 1,500 roubles, part in cash and part to be paid later.”), what does “haggled” mean?
   A. argued over a price
   B. be shiny, as if wet
   C. settled on; chose
   D. spoke of something as having little worth
9. As used in the story (“The younger sister was piqued, and in turn disparaged the life of a tradesman, and stood up for that of a peasant.”), what does “disparaged” mean?
   A. in a civil manner
   B. spoke of something as having little worth
   C. create by putting components or members together
   D. weight down with a load
10. As used in the story (“She had always lived on good terms with the peasants, until she engaged as her steward an old soldier, who took to burdening the people with”), what does “burdening” mean?
    A. floor covering consisting of a piece of thick heavy fabric (usually with nap or pile)
    B. stay the same; remain in a certain state
    C. weight down with a load
    D. land owned outright
11. As used in the story (“The peasants had plenty of land: every man had twenty-five acres of Communal land given him for his use, and any one who had money could buy”), what does “freehold” mean?
    A. settled on; chose
    B. argued over a price
    C. be shiny, as if wet
    D. land owned outright
12. As used in the story (“Pahóm's eyes glistened: it was all virgin soil, as flat as the palm of your hand, as black as the seed of a poppy, and in the hollows differ”), what does “glistened” mean?
    A. be shiny, as if wet
    B. create by putting components or members together
    C. spoke of something as having little worth
    D. in a civil manner

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how greed develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how contentment develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how the devil's temptation develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (greed, contentment, the devil's temptation) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. C (The Devil); 2. D (All the land he can walk around in a day); 3. C (A thousand rubles a day); 4. A (Return to the starting point by sunset); 5. A (Six feet, for his grave); 6. A (argued over a price); 7. A (spoke of something as having little worth); 8. A (argued over a price); 9. B (spoke of something as having little worth); 10. C (weight down with a load); 11. D (land owned outright); 12. A (be shiny, as if wet)

Essay assignments

Essay: Greed

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what How Much Land Does a Man Need? teaches about greed. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Leo Tolstoy develops greed in How Much Land Does a Man Need?. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Leo Tolstoy develops greed across How Much Land Does a Man Need?. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of How Much Land Does a Man Need? (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of greed. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of greed in How Much Land Does a Man Need?. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Leo Tolstoy's choices in How Much Land Does a Man Need? (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of greed, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places How Much Land Does a Man Need?'s treatment of greed in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on greed in How Much Land Does a Man Need? that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on greed in How Much Land Does a Man Need?. Name your critical

method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about greed in How Much Land Does a Man Need?, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on greed in How Much Land Does a Man Need?, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Contentment

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what How Much Land Does a Man Need? teaches about contentment. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Leo Tolstoy develops contentment in How Much Land Does a Man Need?. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Leo Tolstoy develops contentment across How Much Land Does a Man Need?. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of How Much Land Does a Man Need? (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of contentment. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of contentment in How Much Land Does a Man Need?. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Leo Tolstoy's choices in How Much Land Does a Man Need? (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of contentment, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places How Much Land Does a Man Need?'s treatment of contentment in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on contentment in How Much Land Does a Man Need? that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on contentment in How Much Land Does a Man Need?. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about contentment in How Much Land Does a Man Need?, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on contentment in How Much Land Does a Man Need?, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: The devil's temptation

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what How Much Land Does a Man Need? teaches about the devil's temptation. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Leo Tolstoy develops the devil's temptation in How Much Land Does a Man Need?. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Leo Tolstoy develops the devil's temptation across How Much Land Does a Man Need?. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of How Much Land Does a Man Need? (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the devil's temptation. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the devil's temptation in How Much Land Does a Man Need?. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Leo Tolstoy's choices in How Much Land Does a Man Need? (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the devil's temptation, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places How Much Land Does a Man Need?'s treatment of the devil's temptation in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the devil's temptation in How Much Land Does a Man Need? that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the devil's temptation in How Much Land Does a Man Need?. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the devil's temptation in How Much Land Does a Man Need?, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the devil's temptation in How Much Land Does a Man Need?, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.